

Accountability and Ethical Governance - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Accountability and Ethical Governance

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Accountability, responsibility and the complete accountability relationship

2 Internal, external and social control architecture

3 How ethical accountability operates in public administration

4 Indian applications: audit, social audit, political control and digital governance

5 Must-know facts and close-option accountability traps

6 PYQ ownership, cross-links and answer architecture

7 Mains angles and accountability-mechanism selection

8 Social capital as an informal accountability resource

9 Directive decoding and mark-scaled answer construction

10 Study links, audited PYQ routes and final synthesis

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A mission director uploads expenditure data but no authority reviews anomalies or orders correction. Which missing relationship prevents transparency from becoming accountability? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.
- B. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.
- C. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.
- D. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.

Answer: A

Explanation: Accountability is a complete institutional relationship is the controlling principle. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A district officer must explain a decision against published standards before an appellate authority that can reverse it and compensate the claimant. Which concept is complete here? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.
- B. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.
- C. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.
- D. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.

Answer: B

Explanation: Accountability is a complete institutional relationship is the controlling principle. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A block officer is assigned responsibility for wage payments but no one can demand reasons for delay or order relief. Which additional concept is absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.
- B. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.
- C. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.
- D. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Responsibility and accountability are distinct is the controlling principle. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A secretary argues that a subordinate alone is accountable because the subordinate entered the data, although the secretary approved the process. Which distinction should be applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.
- B. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.
- C. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.
- D. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.

Answer: D

Explanation: Responsibility and accountability are distinct is the controlling principle. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

A procurement platform requires prior conflict declarations and later permits audit and appeal. Which temporal understanding of accountability does this illustrate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.
- B. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.
- C. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.
- D. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Accountability works before and after a decision** is the controlling principle. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A department treats accountability solely as punishment after loss has occurred. Which broader preventive and corrective understanding has it overlooked? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.
- B. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.
- C. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.
- D. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Accountability works before and after a decision** is the controlling principle. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A state publishes real-time welfare exclusions but provides no human review or grievance remedy. Why is the system transparent yet incompletely accountable? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.
- B. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.
- C. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.
- D. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.

Answer: C

Explanation: Transparency is necessary but not sufficient is the controlling principle. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A dashboard flags delayed pensions and names the reviewing officer, appeal authority and correction deadline. Which addition converts information into institutional control? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Responsibility is the duty assigned to a role, whereas accountability arises when performance must be explained and justified before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.
- B. Standards, assigned roles, records and reporting create ex-ante discipline, while review, judgment, correction, remedy and proportionate consequences provide ex-post accountability.
- C. Accountability requires an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known standard, an explanation, a judgment and a credible route to correction, remedy or consequence.
- D. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy.

Answer: D

Explanation: Transparency is necessary but not sufficient is the controlling principle. Disclosure and dashboards improve visibility, but accountability additionally needs responsible actors, review against standards, reasoned findings and enforceable correction or remedy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A ministry asks its Chief Vigilance Officer to examine repeated tender complaints and recommend preventive controls. Which accountability layer is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.
- B. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.
- C. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.
- D. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.

Answer: A

Explanation: Departmental vigilance and CVOs are internal controls is the controlling principle. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

An officer assumes every vigilance concern must begin as a criminal prosecution. Which differentiated internal role corrects that assumption? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.
- B. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.
- C. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.
- D. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.

Answer: B

Explanation: Departmental vigilance and CVOs are internal controls is the controlling principle. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A department sends a vigilance matter to the CVC and tells citizens that the Commission will itself prosecute the accused. Which institutional error has occurred? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.
- B. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.
- C. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.
- D. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.

Answer: C

Explanation: The CVC supervises and advises but does not prosecute is the controlling principle. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

The CVC reviews vigilance administration and exercises its statutory role concerning anti-corruption investigation without acting as trial prosecutor. Which distinction is preserved? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.
- B. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.
- C. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.
- D. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.

Answer: D

Explanation: The CVC supervises and advises but does not prosecute is the controlling principle. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A ministry asks whether suspected bribery requires criminal investigation rather than only an internal process. Which differentiated role becomes relevant? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.
- B. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.
- C. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.
- D. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.

Answer: A

Explanation: The CBI investigates within its lawful remit is the controlling principle. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

A disciplinary authority waits for a vigilance body to perform every criminal-investigation function. Which institutional separation has been ignored? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.
- B. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.
- C. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.
- D. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.

Answer: B

Explanation: The CBI investigates within its lawful remit is the controlling principle. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A department claims its internal dashboard makes independent constitutional audit unnecessary. Which external accountability principle defeats the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.
- B. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.
- C. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.
- D. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.

Answer: C

Explanation: **CAG and legislative scrutiny provide external accountability** is the controlling principle.

Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

An audit report is placed before the legislature for committee examination and executive follow-up. Which control layer does this exemplify? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions; it is not itself the body that conducts every investigation or prosecution.
- B. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework; investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline remain distinct functions.
- C. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers support preventive checks, complaint handling and disciplinary processes within administration, subject to their actual authority and procedure.
- D. Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls.

Answer: D

Explanation: **CAG and legislative scrutiny provide external accountability** is the controlling principle.

Independent CAG audit examines public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny and systemic correction; it remains indispensable even when departments possess internal or concurrent controls. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A secretary gives frank recorded advice, then implements a lawful cabinet decision impartially. Which division of democratic and administrative accountability is respected? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.
- B. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.
- C. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.
- D. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Political and bureaucratic accountability are related but separate** is the controlling principle.

Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A minister directs a transfer for partisan retaliation and the official complies without recording objection. Which accountability boundary has failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.
- B. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.
- C. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.
- D. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Political and bureaucratic accountability are related but separate** is the controlling principle.

Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

An officer invokes neutrality to delay a lawful elected-government welfare decision. Which duty within bureaucratic accountability has been neglected? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.
- B. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.
- C. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.
- D. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Lawful political direction does not erase official accountability** is the controlling principle. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A superior demands selective benefits for supporters, and the field officer seeks written directions and review. Which accountable response is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.
- B. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.
- C. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.
- D. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Lawful political direction does not erase official accountability** is the controlling principle. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A treasury system flags duplicate payments before release while later CAG audit tests propriety and performance. Which complementary design is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.
- B. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.
- C. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.
- D. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.

Answer: A

Explanation: Concurrent assurance complements independent ex-post audit is the controlling principle.

Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A department argues that an internal real-time alert conclusively settles responsibility for public loss. Which continuing external requirement is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.
- B. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.
- C. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.
- D. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.

Answer: B

Explanation: Concurrent assurance complements independent ex-post audit is the controlling principle.

Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

Five offices refer a pensioner to one another because no process assigns a final deciding officer. Which structural accountability failure is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.
- B. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.
- C. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.
- D. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.

Answer: C

Explanation: Accountability diffusion weakens responsibility-fixing is the controlling principle. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A scheme publishes a responsibility matrix, escalation deadline and final appellate authority. Which problem does this design reduce? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Civil servants must implement lawful democratic decisions without partisan obstruction, but illegality, discrimination or concealed favour requires reasoned advice, recorded dissent and competent escalation.
- B. Transaction checks, internal audit and real-time exception review can correct problems during implementation, but they complement rather than replace CAG audit and legislative scrutiny.
- C. Ministers answer to the legislature and electorate for policy and departmental outcomes, while officials answer for lawful, impartial and competent advice, execution, records and use of discretion.
- D. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction.

Answer: D

Explanation: Accountability diffusion weakens responsibility-fixing is the controlling principle. When authority, data entry, approval and review are scattered across many unnamed levels, citizens and forums cannot identify who must explain failure or deliver correction. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A Gram Panchayat verifies its own muster rolls privately and announces that a social audit is complete. Which essential safeguards are absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.
- B. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.
- C. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.
- D. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.

Answer: A

Explanation: Social audit requires independent verification and public hearing is the controlling principle. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

Workers compare disclosed muster rolls with attendance and physical works before a Gram Sabha hearing. Which accountability mechanism is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.
- B. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.
- C. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.
- D. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.

Answer: B

Explanation: Social audit requires independent verification and public hearing is the controlling principle. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

A public hearing establishes unpaid wages, but the report is archived without payment correction or action. Which part of social accountability has failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.
- B. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.
- C. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.
- D. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.

Answer: C

Explanation: Social audit is incomplete without action and remedy is the controlling principle. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

An independent unit protects witnesses, publishes follow-up and restores wrongly withheld wages. Which complete social-audit cycle is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.
- B. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.
- C. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.
- D. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.

Answer: D

Explanation: Social audit is incomplete without action and remedy is the controlling principle. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

Workers from different hamlets jointly verify scheme records and support complainants against a powerful contractor. Which governance resource assists accountability? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.
- B. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.
- C. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.
- D. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.

Answer: A

Explanation: Bridging social capital can strengthen social control is the controlling principle. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A grievance forum fails because communities distrust one another and witnesses fear isolation. Which informal resource is deficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.
- B. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.
- C. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.
- D. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.

Answer: B

Explanation: Bridging social capital can strengthen social control is the controlling principle. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A dominant local network pressures members not to testify against a related functionary during a public hearing. Which limitation of social capital is visible? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.
- B. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.
- C. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.
- D. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.

Answer: C

Explanation: Bonding capital can shield wrongdoing is the controlling principle. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

An audit team assumes community cohesion always guarantees honest monitoring. Which close-option qualification should correct that view? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Findings must lead to a time-bound action-taken report, worker remedy, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and safeguards against intimidation or capture.
- B. Trust and cooperation across groups can lower the cost of collective monitoring, testimony and participation, thereby strengthening citizen oversight between formal audit cycles.
- C. A credible social audit separates verification from the implementing agency, proactively opens records, tests them with workers and worksites, and presents findings in a public hearing.
- D. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting.

Answer: D

Explanation: Bonding capital can shield wrongdoing is the controlling principle. Strong in-group loyalty may protect insiders, silence complainants and capture local oversight; social capital improves governance only when it is sufficiently inclusive and rights-respecting. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A benefit portal time-stamps every decision, identifies the deciding officer and permits appeal. Which ethical advantage of e-governance is most direct? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.
- B. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.
- C. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.
- D. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.

Answer: A

Explanation: E-governance can improve traceability and access is the controlling principle. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A department digitises files but leaves exception review and correction unassigned. Why has visibility not yet created full accountability? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.
- B. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.
- C. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.
- D. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.

Answer: B

Explanation: E-governance can improve traceability and access is the controlling principle. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

Elderly pensioners lose benefits because the only filing channel requires a smartphone and English literacy. Which ethical safeguard is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.
- B. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.
- C. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.
- D. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Digital exclusion requires assisted and offline access** is the controlling principle. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A district offers village facilitation, paper fallback and disability support alongside its portal. Which e-governance duty is fulfilled? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.
- B. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.
- C. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.
- D. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Digital exclusion requires assisted and offline access** is the controlling principle. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

A worker's attendance is rejected after repeated biometric failure and no official can override the system. Which ethical design defect is decisive? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.
- B. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.
- C. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.
- D. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Authentication error needs prompt human review** is the controlling principle. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

An officer verifies alternate evidence, records reasons and corrects an erroneous automated exclusion. Which safeguard turns technology into accountable assistance? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.
- B. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.
- C. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.
- D. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Authentication error needs prompt human review** is the controlling principle. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A welfare dashboard publicly displays identifiable health details to demonstrate transparency. Which competing ethical duty has been breached? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.
- B. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.
- C. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.
- D. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Digital accountability includes privacy and explainability is the controlling principle. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A vendor model rejects applications without intelligible reasons or departmental review. Which accountability requirements are absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Online administration must address connectivity, language, disability and literacy barriers through assisted access, workable offline alternatives and equal treatment of comparable claimants.
- B. Biometric or automated failure should not become final deprivation; accountable design requires a human decision-maker, speaking reasons, correction of records and a timely offline remedy.
- C. Digital records, time stamps, workflow visibility and remote service channels can reduce delay, record tampering and opaque discretion when responsibilities and review duties are clearly assigned.
- D. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure.

Answer: D

Explanation: Digital accountability includes privacy and explainability is the controlling principle. Data collection and automated decisions require necessity, security, intelligible criteria, audit logs and review; administrative efficiency does not justify opaque profiling or excessive disclosure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A district finds payments without visible work and immediately suspends all village employment. Which evidence-based restoration step should precede indiscriminate closure? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.
- B. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.
- C. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.
- D. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.

Answer: A

Explanation: MGNREGA restoration begins with record reconciliation is the controlling principle. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

Teams compare demand registers, rolls, bank credits and assets work by work. Which accountability method is being used? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.
- B. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.
- C. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.
- D. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.

Answer: B

Explanation: MGNREGA restoration begins with record reconciliation is the controlling principle. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

An administrator orders recovery from every field worker before verifying roles or giving a hearing. Which accountability standard is violated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.
- B. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.
- C. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.
- D. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Recovery and discipline must follow evidence and due process is the controlling principle. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

Verified ghost payments are mapped to approving roles and referred through lawful recovery and investigation channels. Which corrective principle is applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.
- B. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.
- C. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.
- D. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.

Answer: D

Explanation: Recovery and discipline must follow evidence and due process is the controlling principle. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

Officials arrest an intermediary but leave genuine workers unpaid and records corrupted. Which remedial dimension remains incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.
- B. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.
- C. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.
- D. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Accountability must restore service, not only punish** is the controlling principle. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A district pays verified arrears, corrects records and redesigns controls while pursuing culpable actors. Which balanced approach is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.
- B. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.
- C. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.
- D. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Accountability must restore service, not only punish** is the controlling principle. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A district declares a scheme ethically successful solely because every worksite uploads mobile attendance. Which inference is unjustified? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.
- B. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.
- C. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.
- D. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Monitoring technology does not prove outcome quality** is the controlling principle. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

Officials combine digital monitoring with field verification, social audit and grievance correction. Which qualified use of technology is defensible? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where reconciliation supports wrongdoing, authorities should secure records, hear affected persons and initiate proportionate recovery, disciplinary or criminal referral under competent procedures.
- B. Ethical correction includes unpaid wages, accurate job cards, valid work demand, grievance closure and improved process, alongside responsibility-fixing and deterrent action.
- C. Restoring scheme integrity requires reconciling job cards, employment demand, muster rolls, attendance, wage payments, technical sanctions and physical assets before fixing responsibility.
- D. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Monitoring technology does not prove outcome quality** is the controlling principle. Biometric authentication, mobile monitoring, dashboards and public disclosure can strengthen traceability, yet their presence does not by itself prove fairness, work quality, correct payment or effective remedy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(a): What are the basic principles of public life? Illustrate any three of these with suitable examples. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact wording verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 2. Shared with Topics 04 and 09; Topic 11 uses accountability as one principle and does not claim exclusive ownership.

Model solution

The ARC reproduces the Nolan principles of public life: selflessness, integrity, objectivity, accountability, openness, honesty and leadership. They convert public power into a trust rather than a personal privilege.

Accountability requires an officer to explain a decision before appropriate scrutiny and accept correction. A district programme director should disclose beneficiary criteria, answer audit queries and restore an excluded eligible claimant. Objectivity requires decisions on stated merit; a recruitment board should use published scoring rather than political recommendation. Integrity requires avoiding compromising obligations; a tender member should disclose a relative's bid and recuse where the conflict is material.

Openness is qualified by lawful confidentiality, while leadership requires seniors to model these standards. The principles should be applied with Indian constitutional equality, dignity and due process. Their ethical value lies not in recital but in reviewable procedures, remedies and conduct that retain public confidence.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q8: Honesty and uprightness are the hallmarks of a civil servant. Civil servants possessing these qualities are considered as the backbone of any strong organization. In line of duty, they take various decisions, at times some become bonafide mistakes. As long as such decisions are not taken intentionally and do not benefit personally, the officer cannot be said to be guilty. Though such decisions may, at times, lead to unforeseen adverse consequences in the long-term. In the recent past, a few instances have surfaced wherein civil servants have been implicated for bonafide mistakes. They have often been prosecuted and even imprisoned. These instances have greatly rattled the moral fibre of the civil servants. How does this trend affect the functioning of the civil services? What measures can be taken to ensure that honest civil servants are not implicated for bonafide mistakes on their part? Justify your answer. (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Full official case wording and both demands verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 5. Topic 21 is the primary protection-of-honest-officials owner; Topic 11 supplies fair accountability design.

Model solution

Indiscriminate implication of honest officials converts accountability into fear. It encourages delay, excessive referral, avoidance of innovation and defensive documentation designed for self-protection rather than public service. Capable officers may avoid sensitive posts, while dishonest actors can exploit collective indecision. Yet blanket immunity would create impunity; good faith cannot excuse corruption, gross negligence or concealed conflict.

The correct design separates error, negligence and misconduct. Investigators should examine authority, facts available at the time, recorded reasons, personal benefit, conflict, due diligence and whether similarly placed decisions were treated consistently. Preliminary scrutiny should be competent, time-bound and insulated from political retaliation. Speaking reasons should accompany prosecution sanction or disciplinary initiation. Independent review and appeal can correct malicious or mechanically framed cases.

Administratively, clear delegations, updated manuals, written directions, legal and financial advice, decision logs and peer consultation reduce honest error. Training should distinguish a reasonable policy failure from mala fide action. Protection must remain conditional: destruction of records, deliberate disregard of safety, private gain or repeated reckless conduct warrants action.

Thus fair accountability protects both citizens and honest discretion. It asks an identifiable actor to explain conduct against known standards, but attaches consequence only after evidence, judgment and due process. Such a system

promotes courageous, reasoned administration without normalising either paralysis or immunity. Periodic anonymised review of closed cases can reveal retaliatory patterns and improve standards without prejudging individual guilt in practice.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q10: In a modern democratic polity, there is the concept of political executive and permanent executive. Elected people's representatives form the political executive and bureaucracy forms the permanent executive. Ministers frame policy decisions and bureaucrats execute these. In the initial decades after independence, relationship between the permanent executive and the political executive were characterized by mutual understanding, respect and co-operation, without encroaching upon each others domain. However, in the subsequent decades, the situation has changed. There are instances of the political executive insisting upon the permanent executive to follow its agenda. Respect for and appreciation of upright bureaucrats has declined. There is an increasing tendency among the political executive to get involved in routine administrative matters such as transfers, postings etc. Under this scenario, there is a definitive trend towards 'politicization of bureaucracy'. The rising materialism and acquisitiveness in social life has also adversely impacted upon the ethical values of both the permanent executive and the political executive. What are the consequences of this 'politicization of bureaucracy'? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official wording, including the paper's spellings, verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 6. Topic 11 owns the political-versus-bureaucratic accountability analysis; Topic 09 cross-links neutrality.

Model solution

Democratic administration needs both political responsiveness and a professional permanent executive. Ministers possess electoral legitimacy to choose lawful policy; officials owe frank advice, impartial execution and continuity. Politicisation arises when partisan loyalty, transfers, postings or patronage displace these role boundaries.

Its consequences are serious. Fear of transfer weakens truthful advice and encourages anticipatory obedience. Recruitment, contracts, policing and welfare may become selectively administered, eroding equality and citizen trust. Frequent personnel changes destroy institutional memory, long-term planning and responsibility-fixing. Upright officers become isolated while compliant networks gain protection, diffusing accountability between minister and official. Legislative accountability also suffers when policy direction and operational interference are deliberately blurred. Conversely, bureaucratic resistance to every elected priority can become an undemocratic veto.

Reform should therefore protect the relationship, not sever it. Clear tenure and transparent transfer criteria, written directions, civil-services boards where applicable, reasoned files, conflict disclosure and legislative scrutiny can expose improper intervention. Officials should record material legal and ethical objections, offer workable alternatives and implement lawful final decisions without partisan favour. Ministers should remain answerable for policy and departmental outcomes; officials should remain answerable for legality, competence and execution.

The ethical objective is responsive neutrality: democratic direction bounded by constitutional values and professional administration protected by records, review and consequences for abuse. Public reporting of transfer patterns and committee examination of repeated interference can add deterrence without preventing legitimate administrative reassignment itself.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): An independent and empowered social audit mechanism is an absolute must in every sphere of public service, including judiciary, to ensure performance, accountability and ethical conduct. Elaborate. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, page 3. Topic 11 is the primary accountability route; institutional feasibility must be tailored to each sphere.

Model solution

Social audit converts citizens from passive recipients into participants who test official records against lived outcomes. Independence from the implementing body, proactive disclosure, access to records, verification with users and a public hearing can reveal exclusion, false reporting and poor performance that ordinary files conceal.

Its accountability value depends on follow-up. Findings need a time-bound action-taken report, correction or compensation, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and protection against intimidation. For MGNREGA, workers can compare job cards, muster rolls, wages and physical works. In other public services, the design must respect confidentiality, decisional independence and lawful review; citizen participation cannot become mob pressure on judges or adjudication.

Thus the proposition is strongest as a demand for independent public verification and enforceable response, adapted to institutional function. Disclosure without competent judgment and remedy remains transparency, not complete accountability.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q9: An elevated corridor is being constructed to reduce traffic congestion in the capital of a particular state. You have been selected as project manager of this prestigious project on your professional competence and experience. The deadline is to complete the project in next two years by 30 June, 2021, since this project is to be inaugurated by the Chief Minister before the elections are announced in the second week of July 2021. While carrying out the surprise inspection by inspecting team, a minor crack was noticed in one of the piers of the elevated corridor possibly due to poor material used. You immediately informed the chief engineer and stopped further work. It was assessed by you that minimum three piers of the elevated corridor have to be demolished and reconstructed. But this process will delay the project minimum by four to six months. But the chief engineer overruled the observation of inspecting team on the ground that it was a minor crack which will not in any way impact the strength and durability of the bridge. He ordered you to overlook the observation of inspecting team-and continue working with same speed and tempo. He informed you that the minister does not want any delay as he wants the Chief Minister to inaugurate the elevated corridor before the elections are declared. Also informed you that the contractor is far relative of the minister and he wants him to finish the project. He also gave you hint that your further promotion as additional chief engineer is under consideration with the ministry. However, you strongly felt that the minor crack in the pier of the elevated corridor will adversely affect the health and life of the bridge and therefore it will be very dangerous not to repair the elevated corridor. (a) Under the given conditions, what are the options available to you as a project manager? (b) What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by the project manager? (c) What are the professional challenges likely to be faced by the project manager and his response to overcome such challenges? (d) What can be the consequences of overlooking the observation raised by the inspecting team? (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Full facts and all four official demands verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, page 7. Shared with Topics 09 and 22; Topic 11 supplies responsibility-fixing, scrutiny and corrective action.

Model solution

The project manager may obey and continue; resign or seek transfer; stop work unilaterally; or preserve the stop, seek an independent structural assessment and escalate through competent technical, administrative and vigilance channels. Stakeholders are commuters, workers, taxpayers, the government, contractor, inspecting team and future users.

The dilemmas are safety versus deadline, professional integrity versus hierarchy, public interest versus career, and fair contracting versus ministerial relationship. Obedience risks catastrophic harm, criminal or disciplinary exposure, wasted public money and loss of trust. Immediate resignation protects personal conscience but abandons the public project. Unsupported public allegation may compromise due process. A reasoned technical escalation is strongest.

The manager should secure the site and records, obtain the inspection report, seek written directions and request an independent expert test. He should document the conflict involving the contractor, inform the competent authority and vigilance channel, and propose reconstruction with a revised schedule. Retaliation risk should be recorded through prescribed review channels. No reopening should occur until safety is certified by competent independent expertise.

Ignoring the crack can cause death, structural failure, escalation of repair cost, evidence destruction and institutional impunity. Accountability is not merely later blame: ex-ante standards, traceable decisions and the power to halt and correct unsafe work are essential. Professional courage therefore requires evidence-based resistance joined to lawful escalation. A documented handover should preserve continuity if retaliation removes the manager from the project without warning.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q4(a): What do you understand by the term 'good governance'? How far recent initiatives in terms of e-Governance steps taken by the State have helped the beneficiaries? Discuss with suitable examples. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, page 3. Topic 11 owns the accountability-and-e-governance route; other governance topics may cross-link.

Model solution

Good governance is lawful, participatory, transparent, responsive, effective, equitable and accountable exercise of public authority. E-governance can advance it through time-stamped records, reduced physical discretion, remote access, direct benefit transfer, online certificates and trackable grievances. A beneficiary can know application status and challenge delay rather than depend entirely on an intermediary.

Its success is conditional. Connectivity, language, disability and digital-literacy barriers may exclude the weakest. Biometric failure, poor data, privacy risks and opaque automated rejection can move discretion into technology rather than remove it. Dashboards show transactions but do not establish fairness or remedy.

Therefore beneficiary-centred e-governance needs assisted and offline channels, data minimisation, accessible design, audit logs, speaking reasons, human review and appeal. Technology improves good governance when it makes the responsible officer, standard, decision and correction route more visible; digitisation without review merely automates administrative weakness.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q4(b): Online methodology is being used for day-to-day meetings, institutional approvals in the administration and for teaching and learning in education sector to the extent telemedicine in the health sector is getting popular with the approvals of the competent authority. No doubt, it has advantages and disadvantages for both the beneficiaries and the system at large. Describe and discuss the ethical issues involved in the use of online method particularly to the vulnerable section of the society. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, page 3. Topic 11 uses it for inclusive and accountable e-governance; technology ethics also cross-links Topic 13.

Model solution

Online methods improve reach, continuity, speed, recordability and reduced travel. Telemedicine can connect remote patients; digital approvals can create time-stamped trails. Yet vulnerable persons may lack devices, connectivity, literacy, language support, privacy or a safe place to participate. Persons with disabilities may face inaccessible interfaces, while authentication and data errors can deny essential services.

Other concerns are weak informed consent, confidential data leakage, opaque algorithms, vendor dependence, reduced human attention and difficulty contesting an automated outcome. Formal approval by a competent authority does not by itself resolve these ethical harms.

The response is hybrid and rights-sensitive: assisted access, meaningful offline alternatives, accessible design, minimal data collection, security, intelligible reasons, human review and prompt appeal. Emergency online delivery should be periodically evaluated through user experience and exclusion data. Efficiency is ethically defensible only when no vulnerable person is left without an accountable path to service, explanation and remedy.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2023 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(b): Explain the term social capital. How does it enhance good governance? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf, page 4. Topic 06 is the primary concept owner; Topic 11 owns the shared social-accountability application.

Model solution

Social capital is the network of trust, reciprocity and shared norms that enables people to cooperate. Bridging capital connects different groups, while bonding capital strengthens ties within a group.

It enhances good governance by lowering the cost of collective action, improving information, supporting participation and enabling citizens to monitor services. In an MGNREGA social audit, villagers who trust the process and one another are more willing to compare muster rolls, testify and protect complainants. Community networks can also communicate local needs quickly and improve compliance through legitimate social norms.

The effect is not automatically positive. Bonding capital based on caste, kinship or faction may shield insiders, intimidate witnesses or capture local institutions. Social capital cannot replace CAG audit, departmental control or legal remedy. It strengthens good governance when it is inclusive, rights-respecting and joined to transparent records, independent verification and enforceable follow-up.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(b): India is an emerging economic power of the world as it has recently secured the status of fourth largest economy of the world as per IMF projection. However, it has been observed that in some sectors, allocated funds remain either underutilised or misutilised. What specific measures would you recommend for ensuring accountability in this regard to stop leakages and gaining the status of third largest economy of the world in near future? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Wording verified from the official local paper, books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 4; the scan's text layer omits part of one line, which was read with the printed line and canonical Topic 18 owner. Topic 18 is primary; Topic 11 is only a shared accountability-mechanism cross-link.

Model solution

Public-fund accountability begins with clear responsibility for sanction, release, utilisation, output and outcome. Budget heads should have realistic timelines, measurable milestones and named reviewing officers. Digital transaction trails, procurement controls and concurrent exception checks can identify idle balances, duplicate payments and delay during implementation.

These controls must be complemented by independent CAG audit, legislative committee scrutiny, transparent utilisation and outcome reporting, protected complaints and social audit where beneficiaries can verify delivery. Deviations require speaking explanations, time-bound correction, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and restoration of affected service.

Dashboards alone are insufficient: data quality, field verification, human review and grievance remedy are necessary. Outcome evaluation should distinguish honest implementation difficulty from negligence or diversion. This is primarily a public-fund-utilisation question under Topic 18; Topic 11 contributes the actor-forum-standard-judgment-remedy architecture that converts expenditure visibility into enforceable accountability.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q11: Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Program, MGNREGA was earlier known as National Rural Employment Scheme, NREGA. It is an Indian Social Welfare Program that aimed at fulfilling the 'Right to Work' provisions made in the Constitution. MGNREGA was launched in 2006 under Rural Employment Sector by the Ministry of Rural Development. Main objective of the program is to give legal guarantee of wage employment to the adult members of rural households who are willing to do unskilled manual labour work subject to a maximum of 100 days per year for every household. Every rural household has the right to register under the scheme, job card is issued to the registered, Job Card holder can seek employment; State Government shall pay 25% of minimum wage for the first 30 days as compensatory daily unemployment allowance to the families and of wage for remaining period of the year. MGNREGA work was undertaken by various Gram Panchayats. You have been appointed as an Administrator Incharge of the District. You have been given the responsibility of monitoring MGNREGA work undertaken by various Gram Panchayats. You are also given the authority to give technical sanctions to all MGNREGA works. In one of the Panchayats in your jurisdiction, you notice that your predecessor has mismanaged the Program in terms of: (i) Money not disbursed to actual job-seekers. (ii) Muster Rolls of the Labourers not properly maintained. (iii) Mismatch between the work done and payments made. (iv) Payments made to fictitious persons. (v) Job Cards were given without looking into the need of person. (vi) Mismanagement of funds and to the extent of siphoning of funds. (vii) Approved works that never existed. (a) What is your reaction to the above situation and how do you restore the proper functioning of MGNREGA Program in this regard? (b) What actions would you initiate to solve the various issues listed above? (c) How would you deal with the above situation? (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: All printed facts, seven listed irregularities and all three sub-demands reproduced from the official local paper, books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, pages 9-10. The facts are a GS-IV hypothetical, not evidence of programme-wide conditions. Topic 11 owns this case; Topic 18 cross-links public funds.

Model solution

My reaction would be firm but evidence-led: protect genuine workers immediately, preserve records and avoid collective suspension of employment. Stakeholders are job-seekers, Gram Panchayats, field staff, banks, taxpayers, the predecessor and future beneficiaries.

First, I would constitute an independent multidisciplinary verification team and secure digital and paper records. Work by work, it should reconcile registration and job cards, dated employment demand, muster rolls and attendance, wage calculations, bank credits, technical sanctions, measurements, bills and physical assets. Genuine unpaid workers should receive corrected wages and grievance decisions promptly. Duplicate or fictitious identities, payment-work mismatch and nonexistent assets should be mapped to the officials and intermediaries who entered, verified, approved and paid them.

Second, an independent social audit should receive proactive records, conduct worker and worksite verification and hold a protected public hearing. Its findings require a published action-taken report. Where evidence warrants, I would initiate recovery, disciplinary proceedings or criminal referral through competent authorities, after notice and due process. Complainants and witnesses need anti-intimidation safeguards.

Finally, I would restore demand registration, accurate job cards, timely muster closure, payment reconciliation, asset verification and accessible grievance channels. Biometric or mobile monitoring may strengthen traceability, but authentication failure needs human review and offline remedy. Monthly exception review, responsibility matrices and independent audit would prevent recurrence. The aim is service restoration, responsibility-fixing and institutional correction-not punishment without proof or technology without remedy. That balance sustains trust.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish responsibility from accountability and identify the elements of a complete accountability relationship. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Responsibility is the duty attached to a role: who must sanction a work, verify a muster roll or decide a grievance. It exists even if no later scrutiny occurs. Accountability begins when that actor must explain and justify performance before a forum capable of judgment and follow-up.

A complete relationship therefore needs an identifiable actor, a competent forum, a known legal, ethical or performance standard, reliable information, an opportunity and duty to explain, a reasoned judgment, and correction, remedy or proportionate consequence. In a pension scheme, naming a processing officer assigns responsibility; an appellate authority that reviews delay, orders payment and records systemic correction supplies accountability.

Accountability is not only retrospective punishment. Ex-ante standards, records and reporting shape conduct, while ex-post review and remedy correct failure. Clear responsibility without scrutiny produces unchecked discretion; scrutiny without identifiable responsibility produces blame diffusion. Ethical governance requires both.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Why does dashboard visibility not by itself amount to accountability in digital governance? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

A dashboard provides transparency by making transactions, delays or outcomes visible. Accountability is a thicker institutional relationship. It asks which officer is responsible, what standard applies, who reviews the data, whether the officer must explain an anomaly, who judges the explanation, and what correction or remedy follows.

A welfare dashboard may display authentication failures while excluded citizens remain unable to reach a human decision-maker. It may also contain poor-quality data, conceal unequal access or reward rapid closure through non-speaking replies. Visibility then creates information without responsibility-fixing.

An accountable design assigns exception review, preserves audit logs, protects privacy, gives speaking reasons, permits offline and assisted access, and provides human appeal with authority to restore benefits. Independent audit can test whether reported performance matches field reality. Thus dashboards are useful evidence and early-warning tools, but become accountability only when joined to review, judgment and enforceable remedy.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Explain the differentiated roles of departmental vigilance, CVOs, CVC, CBI and CAG in India's accountability architecture. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

India's accountability bodies occupy different locations and perform different functions. Departmental vigilance and Chief Vigilance Officers are internal controls. They support preventive vigilance, complaint examination, disciplinary processes and improvement of administrative systems within their actual authority.

The statutory Central Vigilance Commission performs vigilance, advisory and specified superintendence functions. It is not itself the prosecuting body and should not be described as conducting every investigation. The Central Bureau of Investigation investigates specified offences within the applicable legal and jurisdictional framework. Criminal investigation, vigilance advice and departmental discipline may interact, but they are not interchangeable.

The Comptroller and Auditor General provides independent external audit of public expenditure and performance for legislative scrutiny. CAG audit can reveal propriety, compliance and systemic failures, but its ex-post character means internal and concurrent checks remain useful for early correction. Those checks never replace constitutional audit.

Effective design routes the problem correctly: administrative weakness to departmental control, credible offence to lawful investigation, systemic public-finance failure to independent audit and legislature, with due process throughout. Collapsing every institution into an all-purpose anti-corruption body creates delay, false expectations and accountability diffusion.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Social audit is more than public disclosure. Examine the institutional conditions required for it to secure ethical accountability. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Disclosure is only the evidentiary beginning of social audit. A credible process must be institutionally independent from the implementing agency, obtain proactive and intelligible records, and verify those records with workers, beneficiaries and physical works. A public hearing or Gram Sabha then permits officials and affected persons to answer the evidence openly.

The cycle becomes accountability only through follow-up. Findings need a time-bound action-taken report, correction of job cards or wages, recovery or disciplinary and criminal referral where evidence warrants, and a route of appeal. Witnesses and complainants require anti-intimidation safeguards; otherwise dominant groups can capture the process. Records should remain accessible in local language and assisted formats.

Social capital can help collective monitoring by building trust across groups, but bonding networks may shield insiders. Therefore community participation cannot substitute for independent CAG audit, departmental controls or due process. Social audit is strongest as the social leg of a layered architecture: citizens reveal ground reality, competent forums judge responsibility, and institutions deliver remedy and systemic correction. Publicity without verification or action is transparency theatre, not ethical accountability.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: A State welfare platform uses biometric authentication, mobile monitoring and real-time dashboards, but vulnerable citizens report exclusion and cannot obtain human review. Analyse the ethical issues and design an accountable remedy. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The platform offers legitimate advantages: traceable transactions, faster detection of duplicate claims, reduced paper manipulation and real-time managerial visibility. Yet its accountability chain is broken. Stakeholders include beneficiaries, persons with weak connectivity or biometrics, field officials, technology vendors, the department and taxpayers.

The ethical issues are digital divide, authentication error, disability and language barriers, privacy, excessive data collection, opaque automated decisions and transfer of responsibility to a vendor or algorithm. A dashboard may record failure without identifying who must correct it. Treating technology as conclusive can convert an administrative convenience into deprivation without hearing.

The immediate remedy is continuity of service through alternate evidence, assisted and offline access, and a named human officer empowered to override erroneous exclusion with recorded reasons. Every adverse outcome should provide intelligible grounds, a time standard and appeal. Data collection should be necessary, secure and access-controlled. Audit logs must identify official and vendor actions without publicly exposing sensitive beneficiary information.

Institutionally, the department should assign exception-review responsibility, sample outcomes through field verification, disclose anonymised failure and correction indicators, audit the vendor, and create compensation or restoration where wrongful denial caused harm. Independent audit and social feedback should test whether digital records match reality.

The verdict is hybrid accountability: biometric and dashboard tools may support traceability, but only human review, offline remedy, privacy safeguards and enforceable correction make the system ethically defensible. Periodic review should test recurring exclusion.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: As district administrator, you discover MGNREGA payments to fictitious persons, incomplete muster rolls, unpaid genuine workers and assets that cannot be located. Set out an ethically accountable restoration plan. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

I would separate urgent service restoration from responsibility-fixing while preserving evidence for both. Stakeholders are genuine job-seekers, Gram Panchayats, field and technical staff, banks, taxpayers, complainants and persons accused of wrongdoing. The immediate risks are destruction of records, continued false payment, collective stoppage of employment and retaliation against witnesses.

First, secure paper and digital records and temporarily restrict only suspicious payment pathways under competent authority. An independent team should reconcile registration, job cards, dated demand, muster rolls, attendance, measurements, technical sanctions, bank credits and physical assets work by work. Genuine unpaid workers should receive prompt correction and speaking grievance orders; the whole village should not be punished for suspected misconduct.

Second, conduct an independent social audit with proactive records, worker and worksite verification, a protected public hearing and a published action-taken report. Map each anomaly to the person who entered, verified, sanctioned and paid it. After notice and hearing, initiate recovery, disciplinary proceedings or criminal referral where evidence and jurisdiction support them. Protect complainants and preserve appeal.

Third, restore reliable demand registration, accurate job cards, timely muster closure, wage reconciliation, asset geo-verification and accessible offline grievance channels. Digital authentication and mobile monitoring should generate alerts, not final denial; human review must correct failure. Monthly exception review, CAG and legislative scrutiny, and periodic social audit should test recurrence.

The plan joins remedy, due process and deterrence. Accountability succeeds when genuine workers receive service, culpable actors face evidence-based consequence and the process itself is redesigned to prevent repetition.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.